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Case Study: The Political Economy of Inefficiency in South Africa

Inspired by Professor Somadoda Fikeni's Testimony at Madlanga Commission | 18-19 Sept 2026.

Executive Summary

South Africa doesn't have a policy problem, it has an implementation and incentive problem. Prof Fikeni's, PSC Chair, called SA "a cemetery of best policies", policies in existence, but the system rewards delay, fear, and non-delivery to the citizens of the public.

What Professor put on record at the Commission

R5 Billion returned unspent by department of Land Reform R13-14 billion returned unspent by UIF, while unemployed queues grow officials suspended on full pay for up to 7 years. Ballistics and backlog up to 1 year. Cases stall, school textbooks dumped in a river in Limpopo/Eastern Cape during tender disputes. Long queues at Home Affairs / Licensing departments creating a market for bribes.

Risk analysis lens risk, what Professor Fikeni described as a single point of failure is that a junior front-line officer with access to ID system with no vetting, low pay means systemic bribery risk and moral Hazard full pay while suspended that means no cost for being out of office. Operational Risk is approximate 80% in acting positions, that means no one makes a decision, decisions are delayed. Concentration risk, political power and admin power in one person (e.g Minister vs Commissioner fight over Task Team). If we can use the Monte Carlo: 10,000 simulations of a citizen applying for ID -median outcome is not "14 days" as policy says, it's "pay at the gate R150 to skip queue."

Economics Lens

This is a technological unemployment fear. The junior clerk at home Affairs knows that if ID applications get automated, their job of stamping 100 forms a day is gone. So, they resist's

the system. Then queues go to 180 days, people pay bribes, and the state returns money it couldn't spend.

Democratized Corruption

When formal service fails, informal market emerges and bribe becomes price to speed up processes. Supply (Government officials) meets demand (frustrated citizens).

What I built in SQL to show my analytical thinking skills based on the problem at hand:

I created mock data to give insights based on the commission's testimony and how we can improve service delivery to ordinary South African citizens.

Suspension Tracker

Question: How much is being paid suspended people?

Unspent Funds vs Service Delivery

Question: How much money is being returned by departments and how has the service delivery been?

Vetting Gap

Question: Which officials in high-risk positions (Home Affairs, Crime Intelligence) with vetting expiry dates?

Recommendations:

1. Prioritize having a protective legislation and whistleblower portal. Revise incentives and real vetting with bank/SARS/property data linkage to end the acting culture.
2. Automate alerts when acting position > 3 months
3. Publish implementation data by sharing datasets and contextual strategies to be used in the execution of an evidence-based intervention, not just policy documents.
4. Use the Monte Carlo simulations for IDs to improve the distribution of identity documents and ballistic testing to test the chance a murder case gets delayed.

In conclusion, corruption is a rational response to a poorly-designed system.

Source: Madlanga Commission of enquiry testimony, 18-19 Sept 2026.

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